

Timeline Compression Trap Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • History • 25-35 min

Category	History	Time	25-35 min
Difficulty	Easy	ID	timeline-compression-trap

Big idea: The scale of a timeline shapes historical interpretation.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Timeline Compression Trap Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Timeline Compression Trap Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: School example: policy change develops over two years, but a viral incident makes it look sudden. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Timeline Compression Trap Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: History example: reform movement builds slowly before one visible law or protest. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Timeline Compression Trap Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: History example: reform movement builds slowly before one visible law or protest. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — The scale of a timeline shapes historical interpretation.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Timeline Compression Trap Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Timeline Compression Trap Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	How do historical representations shape interpretation?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- School example: policy change develops over two years, but a viral incident makes it look sudden.
- History example: reform movement builds slowly before one visible law or protest.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to History.

Activity Steps

1. Give groups the same set of event cards.
2. One group uses a compressed timeline and another uses an expanded timeline.
3. Students place events and write a one-sentence interpretation of the process.
4. Groups compare whether change looks sudden, gradual, inevitable, or contested.
5. Debrief how representation affects historical knowledge.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: How do historical representations shape interpretation?
- Does changing scale change what counts as a cause?
- When does simplification become distortion?

Knowledge Questions

- How do historical representations shape interpretation?
- What does timeline scale reveal or hide?
- When does simplification distort knowledge?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with a timeline where long periods are visually compressed and short events expanded. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...